Everybody's Way Is Welcome

Civic Skill: Voice & Participation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 1 (Identity) & Outcome 2 (Community) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will explore how people with different abilities and needs might share their views in different ways, building the understanding that genuine inclusion means adapting how we listen, not asking children to change how they communicate.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can name a way someone might share their ideas that is different from mine.
- I can think of how to help a friend share their idea if they need support.
- I can say that everyone's way of sharing counts.

MATERIALS

- Simple picture communication symbols or cards
- A small set of basic Auslan signs (yes, no, more, help, happy), ideally introduced with support from a specialist, interpreter, or family member
- Picture book: 'Just Ask!' by Sonia Sotomayor, or 'All the Ways to Be Smart' by Davina Bell
- Assorted communication tools laid out for children to explore

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. BOOK READ-ALOUD (7 min): Read 'Just Ask!' Focus on: different children experience and communicate in different ways, and every way is real.

2. INTRODUCE SIMPLE SIGNS (5 min): With a visiting specialist or family member if possible, introduce a few basic Auslan signs for yes, no, more, help, and happy. Practise together.

3. COMMUNICATION STATION ROTATION (8 min): Children try using picture cards, simple signs, and pointing to share a simple preference — for example, 'which snack do you like?'

4. DISCUSSION (6 min): 'What did you notice about using a different way to share your idea? Was it easy or hard? What helped?'

5. CLOSING (4 min): Create a classroom 'Everyone's Ways' poster combining speech, signs, pictures, and drawings, to be displayed permanently.

EXTENSIONS

- Invite a speech pathologist, Auslan interpreter, or a family member who uses AAC to visit and share
- Keep picture cards and simple signs permanently available and visible in the room
- Connect this lesson explicitly with the 'Many Ways to Say It' session earlier in the program

ASSESSMENT

- Observe children's willingness to try an unfamiliar communication mode
- Note growth in children's awareness of communication diversity across the session
- Learning story: document a moment where a child adapted their communication to support a peer

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Are there children in your room whose communication needs aren't yet fully supported? What practical step could you take this week?
- How did the group respond to trying an unfamiliar mode of communication themselves?
- How does this lesson connect to Article 7.3 of the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities, and to your everyday inclusion practice?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 1 (Identity) & Outcome 2 (Community). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.